The Coding Agent Market in May 2026: Tiers, Approaches, and the Skills Layer

Kabui, Charles

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The AI agent market as of May 2026 has split into distinct tiers and architectural philosophies. The top tier includes OpenClaw as a gateway-first personal assistant in TypeScript with 1,932 contributors, Superpowers as a cross-platform skills framework, Hermes Agent with its self-improving agent-first architecture in Python and 765 contributors, and Claude Code as a coding-first terminal IDE from Anthropic. The second tier includes Codex CLI (Rust, Apache

2.0, 443 contributors), CC Switch as a multi-agent desktop manager built with Tauri 2, and mattpocock/skills for Claude Code-specific workflows.

Two core design approaches emerged. "Gateway-first" tools like OpenClaw connect to everything, acting as universal routers for your digital life. "Agent-first" tools like Hermes focus on getting better at everything through self-improvement loops and reflective phases. Users increasingly run both together, treating them as complementary rather than competing. New concepts that shaped this generation include DESIGN.md for visual design awareness, Symphony for multi-agent orchestration, and ClawHub with 52.7K tools alongside real supply chain risks.

The market is multi-agent, not winner-take-all. CC Switch proves users want all agents running simultaneously, not a single "best" option. Skills layers from Superpowers, mattpocock, and ClawHub now have more combined community engagement than any single agent project. The competition shifted from "which agent is best" to "how do I compose multiple agents into one workflow," and the tools enabling that composition are the ones growing fastest.

Sources:

- OpenClaw GitHub
- Hermes Agent GitHub
- Codex GitHub
- ClawHub Marketplace
- Agent Skills Specification

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